FIFA World Cup 2026 Predictor

Executive Report · Independent ML Forecasting Project · Generated 2026-06-09

> **Executive summary.** This is an independent analytics initiative: a walk-forward Poisson/Dixon-Coles model forecasts tournament outcomes using 150+ years of international results, calibrated against OPTA benchmarks on 2018 (development) and 2022 (confirmation), then rolled forward to 2026. Production forecast (iteration 5) ranks **Spain** as the highest model win probability (10.4%), versus OPTA favourite **Spain** (16.1%).

48	0.742	0.736
TEAMS (2026 SCHEDULE)	BEST 2018 BRIER (ITER 4)	BEST 2022 BRIER (ITER 5)

PARTICIPATING NATIONS

48 qualified teams from the 2026 schedule (USA, Canada, Mexico hosts). Flags via flagcdn.com — not official FIFA branding.



Sweden Switzerland Tunisia USA Uruguay Uzbekistan

METHODOLOGY

- **Data:** Kaggle international results (1872–present), 2026 fixture schedule, OPTA pre-tournament win %.
- **Model:** Attack × opponent defense Poisson goals; 5 iterations (multiplicative → log-linear → weighted decay → Elo anchor → Dixon-Coles τ).
- **Match weights:** Tier A/B/C = 1.0 / 0.85 / 0.5; 2-year time half-life.
- **Validation:** Walk-forward — tune on 2018 World Cup, confirm on 2022, produce 2026 forecast.
- **Bracket:** 10,000 Monte Carlo simulations (48-team 2026 format).

BRIER SCORE & DIXON-COLES

Brier score. For each World Cup match we predict three probabilities (home win, draw, away win). The Brier score is the mean squared error between those probabilities and the actual result (expressed as a one-hot vector). Lower is better: 0 is perfect; about **0.67** is the benchmark from naively guessing one-third for every outcome. We average over all 64 held-out tournament matches to compare iterations and years. Iteration choice for development uses the lowest 2018 Brier; 2022 is reported as confirmation without re-tuning.

Dixon-Coles. Classical Poisson models assume home and away goals are independent; real football shows extra correlation on low scores (0–0, 1–0, 0–1, 1–1), especially draws. Dixon and Coles (1997) multiply independent Poisson probabilities by a correction factor τ (rho, ρ) on those scorelines. Our pipeline learns team attack and defense rates via Poisson negative log-likelihood (iterations 1–4); **iteration 5** adds the τ term in training and when converting goal rates to win/draw/loss probabilities. World Cup match scoring uses neutral venues (no home advantage). Elo anchoring (iter 4+) shrinks team strengths toward a stable rating so single shock results do not dominate.

BACKTEST — BRIER SCORE (LOWER IS BETTER)

Year	Iter	Brier	Model favourite	Win %	Actual winner
2018	1	1.2031	Costa Rica	25.3%	France
2018	2	0.7858	Brazil	17.1%	France
2018	3	0.7594	Brazil	18.4%	France
2018	4	0.7424	Brazil	16.9%	France

Year	Iter	Brier	Model favourite	Win %	Actual winner
2018	5	0.7465	Brazil	16.5%	France
2022	1	1.0913	Portugal	14.1%	Argentina
2022	2	0.7737	Brazil	13.0%	Argentina
2022	3	0.7638	Brazil	21.3%	Argentina
2022	4	0.7363	Brazil	13.1%	Argentina
2022	5	0.7362	Brazil	12.5%	Argentina

2026 FORECAST VS OPTA (ITERATION 5)

OPTA rank	Team	OPTA win %	Model win %	Delta
1	**Spain**	16.1%	10.4%	-5.8pp
23	**Japan**	0.8%	8.4%	+7.7pp
4	**Argentina**	10.4%	8.0%	-2.4pp
3	**England**	11.2%	6.9%	-4.3pp
20	**Morocco**	0.9%	6.4%	+5.4pp
6	**Brazil**	6.6%	6.2%	-0.4pp
2	**France**	13.0%	6.0%	-6.9pp
5	**Portugal**	7.0%	5.0%	-2.0pp
7	**Germany**	5.1%	4.0%	-1.2pp
8	**Netherlands**	3.6%	3.6%	-0.0pp
13	**Colombia**	1.7%	3.5%	+1.8pp
9	**Norway**	3.5%	3.1%	-0.4pp

GROUP-STAGE OUTLOOK (12 GROUPS → ROUND OF 32)

Model picks for group winner, runner-up, and best third-place qualifier candidate. 48-team format: 24 auto-qualifiers + 8 best third-place teams.

Group	1st	2nd	Best 3rd
A	South Korea	Mexico	South Africa
B	Switzerland	Canada	Italy
C	Morocco	Brazil	Scotland
D	Australia	USA	Paraguay
E	Germany	Ivory Coast	Ecuador
F	Japan	Netherlands	Tunisia
G	Iran	Belgium	Egypt
H	Spain	Uruguay	Saudi Arabia
I	France	Norway	Senegal
J	Argentina	Algeria	Austria
K	Portugal	Colombia	Uzbekistan
L	England	Croatia	Panama

KNOCKOUT REACH PROBABILITIES

Monte Carlo estimates of advancing through each knockout round (iteration 5).

Team	P(QF)	P(SF)	P(Final)	P(Win)
Spain	59.6%	41.4%	16.9%	10.1%
Japan	57.8%	38.6%	15.0%	8.8%
Argentina	57.2%	35.6%	13.5%	7.8%
Morocco	74.9%	43.4%	12.6%	6.3%
Brazil	74.2%	42.2%	12.2%	6.3%
England	57.9%	35.1%	11.3%	6.2%
France	57.2%	32.6%	10.9%	5.8%
Portugal	54.3%	29.8%	9.4%	5.1%

Team	P(QF)	P(SF)	P(Final)	P(Win)
Germany	83.0%	27.7%	7.7%	4.0%
Netherlands	45.6%	25.4%	6.7%	3.5%

KEY FINDINGS & LIMITATIONS

- Elo anchoring (iter 4+) reduces overreaction to single shock results (e.g. Saudi Arabia 2022).
- Dixon-Coles τ (iter 5) polishes draw/low-score calibration; marginal gain on 2022 holdout.
- Model still underperforms naive benchmarks on some iterations — ongoing calibration work.
- No xG, squad value, or FIFA rank features (collinearity with Elo); neutral venues at World Cup.
- Live in-tournament updates require re-running production with an updated results cutoff (not automated).

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